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ELEPHANTINE PROBLEM

If it is reward one is after, there must be other ways than through the ministerial route

The argument that we must do everything a minister demands because he has been 'democratically chosen' does not stand up to close inspection. MPs are not chosen by 'the people'—they are chosen by their local constituency parties: 35 men in grubby raincoats or 35 women in silly hats. The further 'selection' process is equally a nonsense: there are only 630 MPs and a party with just over 300 MPs forms the government and of these 300, 100 are too old and too silly to be ministers and 100 too young and too callow. Therefore, there are about 100 MPs to fill 100 government posts. Effectively no choice at all." That's a quote from *Yes Minister*.

The 91st Constitutional Amendment was notified in January 2004 and sets a ceiling of 15 per cent of Lok Sabha seats as the maximum size of the Council of Ministers. Although ministers can also be from Rajya Sabha, there is a cap on 81 ministers. We now have 79 ministers—33 cabinet, seven ministers of state (mos) with independent charge, and 39 mos—close to the cap. Apart from the Humphrey Appleby quote, highlighting selection process and expertise, each cabinet minister costs the country Rs 4 crore a year and each mos costs Rs 2 crore.

Why do we need so many ministers and what do they do? How many mos without independent charge and even with that have any significant work? Why do we need ministries for Chemicals, Fertilisers, Steel, Overseas Indian Affairs, Coal and Planning? Why can't Minority Affairs, Tribal Affairs, Women and Child Development and the North-East be looked after by Social Justice and Empowerment? Why does Power have to be separate from Petroleum & Natural Gas, or New and Renewable Energy? Does it make sense to segregate Heavy Industries from Small Industries and Agro and Rural Industries? Urban Development is separated from Urban Poverty Alleviation, as is Panchayati Raj from Rural Development. There is a rationale for rewarding people. But beyond that, there is no rationale whatever. If it is reward one is after, there must be other ways than through the ministerial route. (That's precisely what states have done after the 91st Amendment.)

Media routinely asks the wrong question. How many

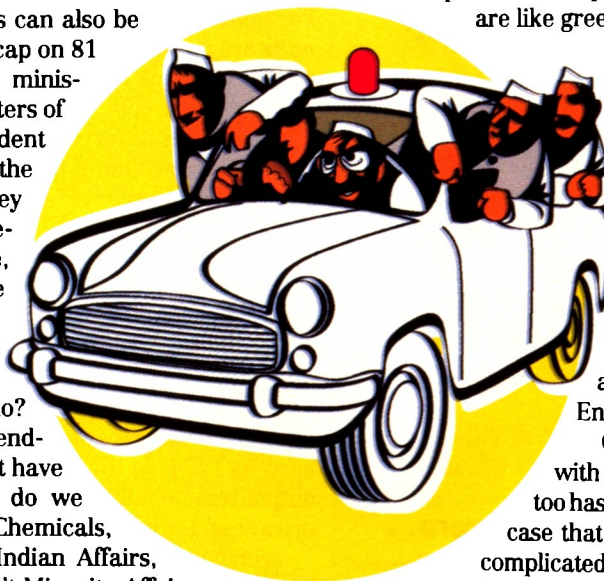
ministries can be slashed? We have always had a preference for "negative lists", be it trade, exchange rate, industrial licensing or investment policy. The definition of the *Paramatman* is a prime example of a negative list. Negative lists are like red lights, characteristic of ministers. With reforms replacing control and licensing with regulation, most ministries have lost their historical roles and have no policy-forming role to play. Indeed, compared to states, the Centre has itself lost relevance. If one has a ministry like Human Resource Development around, it's not only that the ministry is irrelevant. Descartes said, "I think, therefore I am." These ministries "are". Therefore, they act and cause great damage.

We should instead adopt a zero-based budgeting or "positive list" approach to ministries. Positive lists are like green lights. If there is no reason that

justifies the ministry's existence, it should be scrapped. I think we only need 12 ministries—PMO, External Affairs, Rural Development, Home Affairs, Energy, Finance, Social Justice, Commerce and Industry, Physical Infrastructure, Defence, Law and Justice (including Company Affairs) and Environment. At best, one can add one more on Space, Atomic Energy, Science and Technology.

Other countries have prospered with fewer ministries. Historically, India too has had fewer ministers and it isn't the case that policy-making has become more complicated over time. If anything, after 1991, policy-making has become simpler. (Coalition compulsions aren't an acceptable answer.) Are we to deduce that post-Independence, ministers were more efficient than the present lot? In passing, downsizing ministries will also lead to downsizing in bureaucracy and support staff.

On average, each deadweight minister carries excess baggage of 20 direct administrative staff and depending on the ministry, 20 civil servants with their additional support staff. Barring the 91st Amendment, India is headed in the opposite direction, perhaps because Indians are prone to being obese. But a normal body mass index (18 to 25 ministries) is also good for economic health and some studies show inverse correlation between size of government and growth. ■



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